

MarEng Grammar

THE DEFINITE ARTICLE "THE"

Study the following sentences:

- There is **an old man** in our garden.
- Look, **the old man** is coming towards us.
- They have **a house**. **The house** is by **a lake**.
- **The lake** is in the central part of Finland.

We use "a" or "an" with nouns when we talk about something for the first time.

We use the definite article "the" with nouns when we refer to something that is known to us or that someone has already mentioned.

Study the following sentences:

- **The sun** was shining.
- **The sky** was blue.
- What do we know about **the sun**, **the moon**, **the earth** and **the stars** ?
- **The king** is ill.
- **The president** is giving a speech tonight.
- **The government** has not yet made a decision.
- **The sun** rises in **the east** and sets in **the west**.
- **The Captain** gave orders on **the navigating bridge**.

We use "the" with nouns when there is only one of something.

Study the following sentences:

- The books on the table are mine.
- Hurry up! The car is waiting.
- Where are the boys?
- Oh, they are playing in the garden.
- Where are the car keys? In the kitchen.

When something is clear or known to us in/through a given situation we use "the" with a noun although it is mentioned for the first time.

More similar examples:

- He went out into the fresh air.
- What is the weather like?
- Will they arrive in the evening or in the morning?
- Is this the end? No, it is only the beginning.
- The wind is in the north.

Study the following sentences:

NOTE the use of "the" in the following examples:

- This is my flat. Here is the dining room. The bathroom is through here. The kitchen needs renovating. Let's go out onto the balcony.
- Let us make a tour of The Marina . We'll start at the bow. Here is the forecastle; on it is the windlass. Now we are on the main deck etc...

When speaking of a certain place in a given situation we use "the" with nouns denoting the various parts. Often these parts are also "one of a kind".

Study the following sentences:

- **Life** is interesting.
- **Death** comes to all.
- She was interested in **art, literature** and **music**.
- **Time** is **money**.
- **Health** is **wealth**.
- **English history** is interesting.
- I could see **anger, fear, and suspicion** in his eyes.

Abstract nouns in a general sense are used **without any articles**.

BUT:

- We know little **about the life of Shakespeare**.
- **The history of England** is interesting.
- **The water in this lake** is quite clean.
- **The butter that I bought yesterday** was bad.

“The” is used **before abstract nouns or uncountable nouns** if they are **followed by a prepositional phrase or a relative clause**.

THE USE OF THE ARTICLE - SPECIAL CASES

NOTE: No article with the following nouns

- Do you believe in **Heaven** and **Hell**?
- No, but I believe in **Fate**.
- **Parliament** is in session.
- **Congress** has decided.
- **Society** has rejected him.
- The spaceship went out into **space**
- On **land** and at **sea**.

NOTE: No article with the names of meals:

- Have you had **breakfast**?
- Let's meet for **lunch**!
- **Dinner** is at 6 pm.
- What is there for **supper**?

BUT:

- **The dinner we had yesterday** at the Rivoli was delicious.